

MODULE 37 / 40

Northern Flicker

Colaptes auratus

QUICK STATS

Length	11.0 – 12.2 in (28 – 31 cm)
Wingspan	16.5 – 20.1 in (42 – 51 cm)
Weight	3.9 – 5.6 oz (110 – 160 g)
Lifespan	Up to 9 years (avg. 4–5 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Northern Flicker is one of the most distinctive and elaborately patterned woodpeckers in North America — a large, brown, heavily spotted bird that is unlike any other woodpecker in its preference for foraging on the ground rather than on tree trunks. In flight, its white rump patch flashes conspicuously, and the undersides of its wings and tail glow bright yellow (in the Yellow-shafted form of the East) or red (in the Red-shafted form of the West). The bold black chest crescent, spotted breast, and colorful wing linings make it unmistakable. It is the most terrestrial of all North American woodpeckers, spending much of its time probing lawns and open ground for ants.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Northern Flicker is a year-round resident across most of North America, from Alaska and northern Canada south through virtually all of the United States and into Central America. Northern populations are partially migratory. It inhabits open woodlands, forest edges, suburban parks, and any area combining open ground for foraging with trees for nesting. It readily visits suburban lawns and is one of the most widespread woodpeckers on the continent.

DIET & FEEDING

- Ants — the dominant food; digs them from lawns and soil with its long tongue
- Beetles, grubs, and insect larvae from rotting wood
- Wild berries: dogwood, elderberry, sumac, poison ivy, hackberry
- Sunflower seeds and suet at feeders — less common than other woodpeckers
- Grasshoppers and crickets taken from open ground
- Occasionally visits platform feeders for peanuts or corn

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

The Northern Flicker is the only woodpecker that regularly hops across open ground, using its long, barbed, sticky tongue to extract ants from their underground colonies. It consumes more ants than any other North American bird — a single stomach may contain over 5,000 ants. Despite spending much time on the ground, it is also an accomplished tree climber and excavates nest cavities like other woodpeckers. In spring, males drum loudly on resonant surfaces — including metal gutters, chimney caps, and utility poles — to establish territory, producing a territorial din that can be heard from great distances.

NESTING & BREEDING

Northern Flickers excavate nest cavities in dead trees, snags, and wooden structures, typically 6–15 feet above the ground. The entrance hole is about 2.5 inches in diameter. Both sexes excavate over 1–4 weeks. Clutches of 5–8 white eggs are incubated by both parents for 11–16 days, with the male incubating at night. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 25–28 days. One brood per season. Old cavities are widely used by other cavity-nesting species.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Northern Flicker is one of the most vocal woodpeckers, producing a loud, ringing "wicka-wicka-wicka" call that carries through open woodland and suburban neighborhoods. It also gives a loud, single "kleer" call — an emphatic note used in territorial and courtship contexts. Spring drumming is rapid and powerful, often directed at metal surfaces for maximum resonance and volume. The "flicker" name derives from the flickering flash of color visible in flight.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
----------------	---------------	-------------------	-----------

The Northern Flicker population is estimated at 9 million individuals but has declined by roughly 49% since 1970 — one of the steeper declines among North American woodpeckers. Competition with European Starlings for nest cavities, loss of dead trees and snags, and pesticide-driven declines in ant populations are the primary drivers. Retaining snags, installing large nest boxes, and avoiding lawn pesticides are the most effective conservation actions.

FEEDER TIPS

- Flickers rarely use feeders — suet and peanuts are occasionally taken
- The best attraction is a lawn with moist soil and abundant ants
- Retain dead trees and large snags — essential for nesting
- Install a large nest box (2.5-inch hole, 16 inches deep) on a pole
- Avoid lawn insecticides — ants are the flicker's primary food source

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & wings	Brown with bold black barring
Breast & belly	Pale buff with bold black spots
Chest crescent	Bold black — key field mark
Rump	White — flashes in flight
Wing/tail linings	Yellow (East) or red (West)
Head (male)	Gray crown, red nape, black moustache

COLOR ME!

Northern Flicker • *Colaptes auratus* • Module 37

